

Editorial

Vendor1, Consumer2.0

TECHNOLOGY—IN PARTICULAR the Web 2.0 phenomenon—played an interesting role last month in the upcoming 2008 American presidential elections. CNN teamed up with YouTube for a telecast of its popular debate amongst the Democratic presidential candidates. Voters invited via YouTube posed questions directly to candidates and raised issues of concern to *them*—not policy matters of interest to the journalists or the so-called expert panel that so often graces such events.

Viewers of the debate, aired on CNN, saw videos of people asking their own questions—and the Democratic presidential hopefuls were to answer them all. The inclusion of these videos in this year's debate ensured politicians did not skip or gloss over questions. It might be possible to ignore a question (or refuse to answer one) when confronted by a journalist, but you dare not do that with your voter. The CNN-YouTube debate saw the highest viewership for a debate among adults aged 18 to 34 in the cable news history of America.

Though CNN got to choose the video-queries that were aired, this ultra-democratic orientation, as tech would have it, to the American presidential elections has possibly altered the way political debates—at least American ones—will be conducted in the future. It has brought in more accountability to the process of electioneering.

Now let's please not speak about Indian elections being radically revamped by YouTube. Imagine our politicians confronted with a thousand YouTube videos talking about "mundane" issues as taxation and inflation...

But leave aside the politicians—the Web 2.0 phenomenon has certainly reached Indian shores. The effects of YouTube-aided citizen activism were witnessed in India last month: an unhappy resident of the prominent Unitech Builders' residential project—Uniworld City—in Delhi uploaded a video on YouTube detailing his all-too-common builder-related problems. The video graphically portrayed the builder's lackadaisical approach towards its maintenance, the unfulfilled promises of a functional swimming pool and a children's swing. This video was uploaded as a last resort by the residents: their complaints to the builders had fallen on deaf ears, they knew.

YouTube did come to their rescue. Within a few days, there was a sudden turnaround by Unitech—they did what was required. The promised pool is now



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ready to use, and the swings have been fixed.

Months' worth of complaints and letters to Unitech and a community Web site could not achieve what a video aired on YouTube did.

Indian consumer-product companies are warned. They'd better realise the potential of Web 2.0, in particular, the power of the tools it brings to the consumer. If corporate America is crazy about lawsuits, we as consumers in this country are crazy about complaints—and rightly so, looking at the way we are treated. Accountability takes a nosedive when there is confrontation; moral responsibility is absent in this vendor-is-king situation; we in this country sometimes just do not have enough decency, and we've gotten used to it.

Tech can change this; in the social sense, it is the magic leveller. Sure, those with the upper hand won't like it, but nothing will prevent me and you from logging on. Do it.

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Deepak'.

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